

Pahankanuwa Sermon #4

English Translation

Translated from Sinhala

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(Pahankaṇuwa Sinhala Audio Dhamma Sermon No.)

Namo tassa bhagavato arahato sammāsambuddhassa

(Homage to the Blessed One, the Worthy One, the Fully Self-Enlightened One)

Pali Stanza:

Yogā ve jāyatī bhūri,

ayogā bhūrisaṅkhayo;

Etaṃ dvedhāpathaṃ ñatvā,

bhavāya vibhavāya ca;

Tathāttānaṃ niveseyya,

yathā bhūri pavaḍḍhati.

From:

Verse 282 from the Maggavagga (Chapter on the Path) of the Dhammapada

Dear Listeners,

The Sublime Dhamma declared by our Teacher of the Three Worlds, the Buddha—indeed, that Buddha-word—is in truth a path of practice that helps one to be released from the suffering of saṃsāra and to realize Nibbāna. Therefore, no matter how detailedly one studies the Buddha's teachings along with their commentaries and sub-commentaries, or memorizes them, if one does not walk upon that path of practice called virtue, concentration, and wisdom (sīla-samādhi-paññā), the ultimate purpose of the Buddha's teaching is not fulfilled. One cannot realize Nibbāna. To realize Nibbāna, meditation is especially necessary. Without meditation, no one can attain Nibbāna. The word used to convey this meaning of engaging in meditation is 'Yoga'. In other religions, the word 'Yoga' may be used in various other senses. But in our Dhamma, 'Yoga'

means meditative attention (bhāvanā manasikāra)—meditative reflection. 'Ayoga' means not engaging in meditation. Thus, 'Yoga' is engaging in meditation, while 'Ayoga' is not engaging in meditation. Today, we take as our sermon's theme the verse declared by the Buddha to show the difference between these two.

The background story of this verse is a very exemplary one. During the time the Buddha was residing at the Jetavana Monastery, there was a senior monk named Poṭhila. This Venerable Poṭhila was an expert in the Tipiṭaka; he had memorized it entirely and was a teacher instructing five hundred disciples. Judging by today's standards, you know there are various degrees such as 'Tipiṭakācārya' (Teacher of the Tipiṭaka), 'Tipiṭaka Vāgīśvarācārya' (Supreme Master of the Tipiṭaka), and so on; he was a monk worthy of being honored with such great titles. However, although Ven. Poṭhila was filled with learning, he did not direct his mind towards meditation. He did not think about his own Nibbāna or his own escape from saṃsāra, no matter how many disciples he taught. The Buddha felt compassion and a sense of spiritual urgency (saṃvega) regarding this monk, thinking: 'Alas! Though he is a person of such vast learning, he has still not thought about his own Nibbāna.' What was the method the Buddha used to arouse a sense of urgency in this monk? When Ven. Poṭhila came to pay respects to Him, the Buddha would address him as 'Empty Poṭhila' (Tuccha Poṭhila). No matter how the word 'tuccha' (empty/worthless) is used in society, its meaning is 'empty'. Thus: 'Come here, Empty Poṭhila. Welcome, Empty Poṭhila. Sit down, Empty Poṭhila. Ah, well, you may go, Empty Poṭhila. There goes Empty Poṭhila.' In this manner, whenever Ven. Poṭhila came, the Buddha used these words—the word 'Empty'. A great sense of urgency arose in this monk: 'Alas! The Buddha, my Teacher—to me, who am so highly learned and teach such a massive crowd of disciples—uses this word "Empty"! Now, why did the Buddha, out of great compassion, give him this 'insulting name'? It was to arouse in that monk a sense of urgency regarding escape from saṃsāra, and also to shatter the conceit that had arisen due to his learning and his large following.

For someone who practices virtues in this Dispensation, when doing things like meditation, it becomes necessary to seek various instructions under the guidance of a teacher. If one is to receive such instructions, there must be humility. This monk might have been thinking, 'Now I know everything.' A full vessel cannot be filled again. It must be emptied to be filled. It was with this intention of emptying and shattering conceit that the Buddha began addressing this monk as 'Empty'. Yet, this monk did not get angry because of it. He did not harbor hatred or ill-will toward the Buddha, thinking, 'He is disrespecting me.' Understanding his own state, he then decided: 'Now, I must abandon all these disciples and leave. I must go to some forest monastery, to a remote forest, and meditate.' Having made this

resolution, the next morning he taught his disciples for the last time, and as the very last disciple departed, in a way that no one could see or understand—as if in disguise—not exactly in disguise, but in a manner unseen by anyone, even before dawn, he departed. Having departed, he traveled hundreds of leagues away and arrived at a certain forest monastery. In that forest monastery, there resided thirty monks. It was a forest monastery where thirty Arahants resided. This monk went to the chief monk of that monastery and pleaded: 'Alas, Bhante, please be a refuge to me.' That is, to be a refuge for Nibbāna. The chief monk first said, 'Alas, is not your reverence a person of such great learning? Is it not from people like you that even we must learn something?' Ven. Poṭhila replied, 'Alas, do not say so, Bhante. I have come here seeking a refuge; please give me a meditation subject (kammaṭṭhāna) for Nibbāna.' To break his conceit, the chief monk sent him to the second monk. That monk sent him to the next monk. Going on like this, they finally sent him to a seven-year-old novice monk (sāmaṇera) who had recently ordained and was at the very end of the community of monks. This novice monk was no ordinary person either. He was an Arahant. When Ven. Poṭhila approached, this young novice, who was indeed a great Arahant, was sewing a robe in a quiet spot. Ven. Poṭhila went up to this novice monk, paid respects, and pleaded: 'O virtuous one, please be my refuge, please help me.' The novice monk also said, 'Alas, Bhante, you are a very elderly, highly educated, and deeply learned monk. When even we must learn things from you, why do you speak like this?' Ven. Poṭhila replied, 'No, no, do not say so. I have come with the hope of realizing Nibbāna. Please be my refuge. If you tell me to, I am even ready to jump into a fire,' thus expressing his obedience. Then, to eradicate his conceit and test his obedience, the young monk pointed to a pond nearby and said, 'If that is so, Bhante, step into that pond over there.' Ven. Poṭhila, who was wearing high-quality, valuable robes, stepped into the pond with those very robes on. Just as he stepped in, and the edge of his robe was barely wet, the young Arahant novice called out, 'Come back, Bhante,' and then began to give him the lesson.

You, meritorious people, can think a little about how this must have been. A seven-year-old novice monk—a clever, skillful novice, but indeed an Arahant. And that senior monk was highly learned, with graying hair, possessing a very dignified appearance. Yet, that senior monk sat in a squatting posture and was now learning this lesson to realize Nibbāna. He was ready to learn a lesson from this seven-year-old novice, a lesson he had been unable to learn all this time. What was the lesson this Arahant novice gave? He gave a simile that anyone can take deeply to heart, or understand very simply. 'Then, Bhante, let us suppose there is an anthill with six holes. A monitor lizard entered through one of these six holes. If one wants to catch this monitor lizard, what should one do? One must close five of the holes and watch over the single hole through which the

monitor lizard entered. While watching there, one can catch the monitor lizard. In the same way, Bhante, we have six senses—like the anthill, in this body of ours. Various objects enter through these six sense doors. If we want to "catch" those objects that have entered'—here, 'catching' means, in a deep sense, to comprehend them, to 'grasp' them. In modern parlance, we say, 'I couldn't catch what was said.' It is that kind of catching meant here. Catching the monitor lizard means, regarding the object—various objects, when we think of various things we call them 'objects'—it means correctly comprehending the true nature of the object; that is what is called catching the object. 'Just as one closes those five holes to catch the monitor lizard, among these six senses, one must close the five doors of the external senses, namely the eye, ear, nose, tongue, and body, and engage in guarding this door called "mind", called the "thought-mind".' That is the idea. There was no need to explain further. As soon as the young monk spoke this simile, Ven. Poṭhila's past merits surfaced, and he understood it deeply. Next, as he was understanding it, the Buddha, watching this event from hundreds of leagues away, through His Buddha-knowledge, in order to further encourage Ven. Poṭhila at that final moment—to encourage him to exert himself in that meditation subject—uttered the verse we took as our theme earlier.

Yogā ve jāyatī bhūri

ayogā bhūrisaṅkhayo

etaṃ dvedhāpathaṃ jñātvā

bhavāya vibhavāya ca

tathāttānaṃ niveseyya

yathā bhūri pavaḍḍhati

'Yogā ve jāyatī bhūri'—Yoga means engaging in meditation, meditative attention (bhāvanā manasikāra). Through that meditative attention, one can gain great wisdom as vast as the earth. One can obtain a great result. 'Ayogā bhūrisaṅkhayo'—But if there is no such meditative attention, no such engagement, what happens there is the decline of wisdom. Wisdom is destroyed; understanding is lost. 'Etaṃ dvedhāpathaṃ jñātvā - bhavāya vibhavāya ca'—understanding these two paths, this crossroads—fully understanding these two paths diverging in two directions—'tathāttānaṃ niveseyya - yathā bhūri pavaḍḍhati'—'in whichever way wisdom grows, practice in that way, walk on that path, turn towards that path.' This is how the Buddha advised Ven. Poṭhila through this verse. It is recorded that, encouraged by this instruction, Ven. Poṭhila very rapidly applied meditative attention and became an Arahant. From

this, we can understand that there is a depth within that verse sufficient to aid the realization of Arahantship. Why? Because the young novice monk had presented the Dhamma Ven. Poṭhila had realized himself as a meditation subject through that small simile—the simile of the monitor lizard and the anthill.

Now, we too can draw many lessons from this story. Let us first look at that. First of all, from this story, we see the difference between knowledge and wisdom. Today, this is something many people mix up. This is an era where knowledge is overflowing. In the name of science and other various arts and sciences—when you look at a library, it is full of books. There is such an overflowing store of knowledge in the world. But wisdom is not that. Wisdom is subtle understanding. Most people lack it. Especially, wisdom here means the deep understanding that helps realize Nibbāna—the deep understanding of the Four Noble Truths. Most people do not have that. Nor do they exert themselves for the sake of wisdom. Instead, carrying a burden of knowledge, crushed under its weight, they spend their lives and finally die, sometimes to be reborn in the lower realms, as animals, or ghost worlds. Why? A person cannot escape saṃsāra through that accumulation of knowledge. For the sake of wisdom, one must walk upon that path of virtue, concentration, and wisdom (sīla-samādhi-paṇṇā) and receive training in it. Or to put it another way—by concentrating the mind through a certain meditation subject, and developing the three characteristics of impermanent (anicca), suffering (dukkha), and non-self (anattā), realizing the stages of awakening is what is called wisdom. This difference between the two is well illustrated by Ven. Poṭhila, who, despite having qualifications worthy of receiving various degrees, did not realize Nibbāna, which is the true purpose of the Buddha's teaching. He had not even attained the stage of Stream-entry (Sotāpanna). But that seven-year-old novice monk, who was a newly ordained monk—whom we call 'the small monk'—was not small at all; he was a great Arahant. Such is the vast gap between knowledge and wisdom.

Next, when we think of the word 'Empty' (tuccha), which seems like an insult from the Buddha, we can understand that the fundamental thing required to practice a meditation subject and to be disciplined according to it is humility. Although Ven. Poṭhila had such shortcomings initially, how humbly did he seek refuge from the novice monk at that moment! This is exemplary for everyone. It is an occasion worthy of drawing a discipline from. Thus, he demonstrates the quality of humility. It is an example to the world. Despite possessing great academic learning, in the presence of one who had supramundane realization, he humbly and respectfully sought advice. Ven. Poṭhila set a wonderful example.

On the other hand, look at the simile given, and also the discipline that showed the spiritual power of that novice monk. He told Ven. Poṭhila to step into the

pond, and Ven. Poṭhila obeyed that spiritual power. Next, the simile given by the young monk: the simile of the monitor lizard that entered the anthill. This anthill carries a deep meaning. The simile of the anthill is shown in the Dhamma itself. This physical body, born of mother and father, nourished by food and drink, and constructed from the four elements of earth, water, fire, and wind—arising from these four elements of earth, water, fire, and wind—is compared to an anthill. The six holes of this physical body are what was mentioned. The five external sense doors are the eye, ear, nose, tongue, and body. Why are these called 'holes'?—They are 'doors'. Through these doors, we take in various objects. Forms are seen by the eye. Sounds are heard by the ear. Odors are smelled by the nose. Tastes are tasted by the tongue. Tangibles are felt by the body. Likewise, thoughts come to the mind. In this way, objects stream in through these six doors. But there is a specialty here. The objects taken in by those five external senses—the eye, ear, nose, tongue, and body—the experience of those streaming objects, their consumption, is done by the mind. If we consider this like a picture, those five external senses are around the periphery, and the mind is in the center. All messages from those five—sensory messages—are deposited in the mind. Even if we think about that anthill, the mind is like the topmost hole of the anthill. That is the chief one. The five external senses are like the five holes around it. We can think of it like that for a moment. Usually, we think that the eye took the object, that the ear took the object. But no matter from where they are taken, these go and deposit themselves in the mind.

The mind is chief. This is the most special and supreme statement in the Buddha's teaching. Even if modern science does not take this into much consideration, the Buddha's teaching gives the chief place to the mind. The Dhammapada begins its first two verses with the words: 'Mano-pubbaṅgamā dhammā, mano-seṭṭhā manomayā.' This is like a fundamental principle of the Buddha's teaching. 'Mano-pubbaṅgamā dhammā'—here, 'dhammā' means the objects of the mind. We can call them 'things'. In everything we consider as 'things', the mind is the forerunner. The mind is chief to these. 'Mano-seṭṭhā'—the mind is supreme. 'Manomayā'—when we really reflect, these are mind-made. In things taken as 'forms' or 'sounds' and so on, it is the mind-connected part that the Buddha highlights most. They are, as it were, constructed by the mind itself. Therefore, this problem must be resolved through the mind itself. What is meant by resolving the problem through the mind itself? It is by reflecting on these incoming objects. Through reflecting on these objects, it is the comprehension of their true nature—their true nature according to the Dhamma. What does the ordinary worldling do? To see a form coming to the eye more clearly, they run after it. They run after the sound coming to the ear. These are perceptions (saññā). The Buddha compared perception (saññā) to a mirage. What is a

mirage? In the hot season, a deer, seeing a shimmering, vibrating appearance on the ground caused by climatic and weather conditions, is deceived into thinking it is water and runs after it. The more it runs, the further it recedes. Therefore, it is called a mirage, 'mṛgatrṣṇikā' (deer-thirst). The thirsty deer runs after it. The Buddha compares perceptions (saññā) to this very mirage. If so, how much do we exhaust ourselves to see clearly a form that appears to the eye, to the point that microscopes are not enough, telescopes are not enough! In that manner, we analyze and analyze them. But one does not draw closer to the Dhamma through that. One does not draw closer to seeing the reality declared by the Buddha. It does not ultimately help in realizing the three characteristics of impermanent (anicca), suffering (dukkha), and non-self (anattā).

It is the same with sound and other things. We run far after them. What is the danger of this running? Why do we run? It is because of desires for them. Desire is something that grows. Running after these perceptions is what causes the growth of defilements, which are called by various names such as craving (taṇhā), desire, and greed. Instead of that, what is advised—especially in insight meditation (vipassanā bhāvanā)—is to briefly note everything. That yogi, the meditator (yogāvacara), is on a path to Nibbāna, a journey to Nibbāna. Now, even if we are going on a long journey, if we are traveling with that journey as our target, and if we stop our vehicle everywhere along the way because 'here is a good view, here is a good song' to see and hear them, we will not be able to complete our journey. It causes delay. Therefore, a person who aspires to Nibbāna without delay, when engaging in that work of yoga, in meditation, in meditative attention, does not chase after a form that is seen. He does not run after it. Instead, he gives a note to the mind: 'form, form,' reflecting twice in this manner: 'this is merely a form.' That is what is called noting/reflecting—meditative attention (manasikāra). 'Form, form.' Next, regarding a sound as well—if it is a song, without analyzing whose song it is, or what kind of song it is, the one who has sat down for meditation notes: 'sound, sound' and ends it right there. 'sound, sound.' In the same way, regarding odors too—that too is a certain sensation, an odor or fragrance. He notes it briefly and ends it right there; in that manner. Or else, even if a thought arises, without letting that thought grow, without letting it expand, he notes it as a thought. It is merely a thought that is noted here. Through this, instead of running after the mirage, the mind can be stopped. Stopping this running mind is the special exercise done through this.

What have we been doing for a long time in this saṃsāra? Like the deer running after the mirage, we ran after the perceptions received through our senses. There is never any satisfaction. The deer runs to quench its thirst, but its thirst only increases, and it cannot find water to end it, because there is no water there. In the same way, to quench our desires, we run after a 'thing' created by the mind.

The things we think of as 'things' are those very objects. But not a single one of them can be caught by us. Their true nature cannot be grasped. We cannot be satisfied by looking with the eye or hearing with the ear. Instead, the Buddha says to close those five doors and note the things that come to the mind in the manner described. Even the incoming thought is noted as a thought—without submitting to that thought, without allowing it to grow. Recognizing it as 'thought, thought,' it is ended right there. In this way, as in 'nipping it in the bud' (*lat-tana lop karanavā*), this insight attention (*vipassanā manasikāra*) is what is meant here by 'catching the monitor lizard'; it is the comprehension of the true nature of the object. This 'monitor lizard'—these objects—have been deposited in the mind in a very subtle way over a long period in this long *saṃsāra*. The objects we formed due to the perceptions coming to this mind in the past *saṃsāra* lie as if asleep within the mind. They wake up and try to escape through those five external senses. A certain past perception regarding a form coming to the eye arises—arising from within the mind—and grasping the external form, it runs after it, thinking, 'Ah, what a beautiful form!' It runs after it, thinking, 'Ah, what a good song, what a sweet sound!' These also arise from the mind. Once they arise and start running after the five external senses, they cannot be stopped again. Instead, what is done? Closing those five doors, the meditator, without giving room to them, treats them briefly, nips them in the bud, and remains watchful over the mind. What is used to help maintain this watchfulness? That is what is called mindfulness and clear comprehension (*sati-sampajañña*). 'Sati' means mindfulness. 'Sampajañña' can be called 'clear understanding' or 'awareness'—the ability to understand something, which means a power of comprehension. Thus, we can call it mindfulness and wisdom. Possessing mindfulness and wisdom, one becomes aware of something oneself—not making others aware, but becoming aware oneself: 'the nature of this is such.' If it is a form, that too is a mirage. That too is perception. Therefore, without running after it, one stops right there, noting: 'it is merely a form, it is merely a sound.'

It is through noting in this manner that one can gradually free oneself from perception (*saññā*). It is by freeing oneself from perception that wisdom (*paññā*) can be brought forth—that deep understanding. What is that deep understanding? As declared by the Buddha, everything in this world has an impermanent (*anicca*) nature. A person must realize this impermanence (*aniccatā*) for themselves. Through this noting, the power to realize it arises in a person. If we reflect on impermanence (*aniccatā*) in more detail, in everything there is an arising (*jāti*) and a passing away. Arising and passing away—these two are what is called impermanence (*aniccatā*). Whether we take form, feeling/sensation (*vedanā*), perception (*saññā*), formations (*saṅkhāra*), or consciousness (*viññāṇa*)—this entire five aggregates is impermanent (*anicca*). It

is this group of five aggregates that we designate as 'I' and 'mine'. This is a pile of form. Sometimes we take a photograph and proudly say, 'my form.' What was recorded there? A series—a continuity—of forms changing at extreme rapidity. This is shown as a single thing by that perception, like a mirage. There is such a deceptive nature in the world. Due to the weakness in the structure of these senses, we do not see that rapid change. This is because of what is called the 'perception of compactness' (ghana-saññā). There is a tendency for everything in the world to appear as a solid thing, a dense thing, a real thing, a permanent thing. The mirage seen from afar is thought of as water. But there, only a great shimmering, vibrating mass exists. In the same way, not only that which is far, but this physical body of ours also changes moment by moment with extreme rapidity. That is form. Next, feeling/sensation (vedanā) is also like that. We say 'Alas, sensation!' thinking of it as a single thing. But there too, when one notes with mindfulness and wisdom in the manner of meditative attention, it is seen. There too, exists only a heap of feelings. Likewise, perception (saññā) is also a pile of layers. It is through a pile of perceptual layers that we recognize someone. With extreme rapidity, we take that pile of layers as one due to the perception of compactness—as a form. Similarly, formations (saṅkhāra), which are our intentions—they too arise and pass away with extreme rapidity. Even consciousness (viññāṇa), though we call it 'the mind,' though we call it 'my mind,' arises and passes away with a speed that is 'unimaginable'. While such a state exists in the world, we usually take these as one through the perception of compactness and designate them as 'I' and 'mine'. When we say 'I', if there is an 'I', there must also be something that belongs to me. So, it is by trying to divide these two that we create this saṃsāric knot. 'I' and 'my things.' In this way, due to that perception of compactness, a delusion (moha) arises.

When someone engages in that meditative attention, establishing a certain state of concentration (samādhi) and stilling the mind—first, by not letting the running mind run, and keeping watch over the mind—and then, as they go on noting more deeply, they see that there is only a heap of arising and passing away here. There is no 'thing' that arises, nor any 'thing' that passes away. Ultimately, even the thing taken as a 'thing'—that too is not there. The feeling comes that here is only a mass of vibrations. Though we say 'thing' in ordinary parlance, even this object—this object taken as a 'thing'—it is seen that there is nothing here to grasp anew. Why? Because that perception of compactness is removed and it is seen as a multitude—everywhere, wherever one looks. When that realization approaches a meditator (yogāvacara), his own body, feelings, perceptions, and everything else are understood as a heap of vibrations. That cannot be shown to another. It is understood by oneself. That is what is called 'direct realization' (pratyakṣa). Through such an understanding, next, a disenchantment arises, thinking: 'Is it

not a thing of arising and passing away that I am grasping as "I" and "mine", and desiring?' Likewise, when the effort to reproduce these is lost, what is seen more is the vanishing, the breaking up nature. Because of that breaking up, a fear arises. Now, if we are holding onto something, if we are grasping something seeking a refuge, when that thing we are holding onto, that thing we are grasping breaks, a certain fear and urgency arises in us. In the same way, to that meditator, as he goes on noting the five aggregates in this manner, the understanding comes: 'There is nothing to be taken here. There is nothing to hold onto. This is a very dangerous situation. It is while sitting on a pile of breaking foundations in this entire saṃsāra that we are singing joyfully.' Therefore, in truth, it is due to delusion (moha) and ignorance (avijjā) that we travel for a long time in saṃsāra, like the deer running after the mirage. Instead, when that understanding arises here, when wisdom arises, it is seen that this form, feeling/sensation (vedanā), perception (saññā), formations (saṅkhāra), and consciousness (viññāṇa)—all of which were taken as 'I' and 'mine'—are changing and breaking up with extreme rapidity. They arise and pass away. It is in this manner that the insight knowledges mature.

Therefore, we must consider the value of this attention (manasikāra). Attention is something done entirely within the mind. The meditator does not do any extraordinary work in the world, like a hen hatching eggs. What he does is not visible. But it is through this attention done inside the mind that his wisdom (paññā) grows. It is difficult for the ordinary worldling to understand this. Through this meditative attention, at some point, it gradually becomes clear to a person: 'In this entire saṃsāra, I have been engaged in a futile journey due to ignorance (avijjā) and craving (taṇhā). Taking this breaking thing, this rapidly changing thing, as "I" and "mine", and being submerged in a stream of defilements, a heap of defilements created because of it, I spend this saṃsāra. We undergo various births (jāti) according to karma.' As this understanding deepens and deepens, a person gains the strength to let go of this. Now, when we say 'letting go,' the feeling comes to a person that something one is holding is slipping away from one's hand. But if we look at it that way, a question arises as to how one can let go of the five aggregates. Though we say 'letting go' in words, something completely different happens here. As that meditator goes on noting in that manner, he sees this arising and passing away, and next, its breaking up. It begins to be understood as breaking up even faster than it arises. Next, because of this very thing, a certain fear and urgency arises. Likewise, the danger of this is seen, and the understanding comes that there is nothing to grasp here. Next, the comprehension arises that one must be freed from this—the need to be freed from this. The path to that freedom is that disenchantment. Now, we know well that a person who likes to be well-groomed, whether a young man or a young

woman, dressed in all their finery and ready to go to a grand festival—if someone throws a dead dog, a dead snake, or a corpse onto their shoulders, how quickly would they shake their shoulders and cast it off? In the same way, when that understanding comes, regarding the dangerous nature of these, a certain disgust arises within the mind. A disenchantment arises. That disenchantment is not something to be told to others. That disenchantment arising from within oneself is what is used as an aid to escape from saṃsāra. Why? Because the bondage of saṃsāra is based on craving (taṇhā), on desire, on attachment, which is the mental grasping called holding/fuel (upādāna). What is here is a mental grasping. At this moment, we are not holding anything with our hands. But you, meritorious people, know very well how many things we are holding with our minds. What is meant by saying we have owned this entire world? Mental grasping. How did the kings who conquered the entire world own the world? They grasped it with the mind, with craving (taṇhā). They thought, 'this is mine.' Even this physical body of ours does not belong to us, in truth. For it is said that a multitude of ninety-thousand families of worms live inside it and excrete in it. It belongs to all of them. That is why it is called 'shared with many' (bahu-sādhāranā). This body is something that belongs to anyone. Likewise, our lands and properties are shared with thieves and enemies. They are shared with insects, monkeys, and other animals. But 'ours'—everything is ours. The country is ours, the village is ours, the world is ours—we usually designate all of this as ours. But when we look at the reality of this, not a single one of these is ours. The Buddha declared this truth, which is usually considered bitter. Though bitter, if it is the truth, we must accept it.

It is through such a vision of truth that a person is able to escape from this saṃsāra. The path that helps towards this is this meditative attention. Therefore, you meritorious people must reflect today. A person might think that the stories we present as similes are things that cannot be put into practice in daily life. But how did that seven-year-old novice monk attain such a sublime state, the state of Arahantship? Was it by reading books? Was it by gaining a vast store of academic knowledge? No. It was through meditative attention. That young monk caught the monitor lizard in the anthill correctly. Closing the five holes of the external senses, and catching the monitor lizard correctly through that hole called 'mind', is why he became an Arahant. Therefore, a highly practical lesson for daily life was taught here by this seven-year-old novice monk to Ven. Poṭhila. We too must make use of it. We must make it a practical thing in our daily lives. In this day and age, we often say 'it is impossible.' But through this simile, we see that we can create a moment for this meditative attention even in our daily lives. Some might wonder how these can be stopped merely by noting them in the manner described. One might think, in daily life, 'should we not run after these?' But the

meditator does not think from such an ordinary perspective. For a long time, we have been in a great deception. A great deception called ignorance (*avijjā*) and delusion (*moha*) has been created due to these five senses. If we are to understand their true nature, a certain discipline is necessary, as declared by the Buddha. Just as you have undertaken today, one must first undertake a certain virtue (*sīla*) and discipline body and speech. Establishing oneself on that virtue, to concentrate the mind means to make the mind one-pointed. It is to a concentrated mind that this reality appears. To a scattered mind, the reality of the world is not understood. Therefore, removing the causes that distract the mind, one must still the mind on some meditation subject.

After concentrating the mind in that way, next, if this noting is done correctly, one begins to understand gradually: regarding the thing we took as one—through the perception of compactness—here, there is only a multitude, a heap. Why is it called a heap? It is understood as a heap because each one is understood separately. When we look at a broom and examine whether it is a broom, we see that here is only a heap of ribs (coconut-leaf midribs). Then, each rib is seen separately. Within that separate seeing, there are those phenomena of Name-and-Form (*nāmarūpa*). That is an occasion when a certain deep Dhamma matter called Name-and-Form (*nāmarūpa*) is understood. According to the Dhamma declared by the Buddha, in truth, there exist here only two things: Name-and-Form (*nāmarūpa*). There is no 'I' here. That is the Buddha's teaching. Although we think 'Name' (*nāma*) means a name, it consists of these five phenomena: feeling/sensation (*vedanā*), perception (*saññā*), intention/volition (*cetānā*), contact (*phassa*), and attention (*manasikāra*). Even in daily life, we experience some feeling—and based on that feeling, we form a certain recognition, which is perception. Based on that recognition, we think—intention. Through those thoughts, we make a certain contact, and direct our attention to a certain place. This is what is called mental phenomena (*nāma-dhamma*).

Next, what is the Form (*rūpa*) part of this? Form (*rūpa*) is considered as these four great elements of earth, water, fire, and wind. These four elements are mixed in an extremely subtle manner. In what we call water, the other elements are also included. But the water-element (*āpo-dhātu*) is more prominent in it. Therefore, we call it water. In this manner, mixed in a highly wondrous way, these four elements are like four ungraspable ghosts—the great primary elements (*mahābhūta-dhamma*). It is from these four elements that this body of ours is constructed. Now, keeping others from getting close to our bodies which we designate as 'I' and 'mine', keeping watch from afar, cleaning it—after this physical body dies and is cast into a cemetery, how do others recognize it? Ultimately, everything turns back to earth. Taking the essence of this earth as food is how this body was built. Over a long period, for a period of twenty, thirty,

or a hundred years, this physical body was built up. Next, when it decays, it also turns to earth. Arising from earth, it becomes earth. That is what is there. Thus, there are only the four elements. But we do not understand this in our daily lives. The mind does not understand it. To the meditator, this is understood in an extremely subtle manner. So, this is what is called Form (rūpa). In the language of the meditator, when we say 'Form' (rūpa), what is understood? The four elements of earth, water, fire, and wind. While others, in various ways, say, 'what a beautiful form, what a gorgeous form, what a lovely form indeed!' to the one who has that deep wisdom, the understanding comes: 'what is there here? Only the four elements.'

It is the same with what is called the mind. Or rather, the 'mental phenomena' (nāma-dhamma) part. There too, exists a feeling that is directly realized by oneself. Through that, there is a perception that is taken. Even while sitting right now, there is a certain feeling, in such a way that one can say, 'it hurts in such-and-such a place.' Next, there is a recognition, 'has a mosquito bitten me?' A feeling arises. Next, regarding contact—regarding the place of collision—an understanding comes. All of this is done through the noting called attention (manasikāra). Ultimately, when we look, it is attention. It is through attention, therefore, that one understands the emptiness of an object. We also started with the story of 'Empty Poṭhila'—regarding emptiness. That is from another perspective. Now, here, ultimately what comes is the emptiness called voidness (suññatā). This means a penetrative vision of the object. What the ordinary worldling does is run after an object, like the deer running after the mirage. What the meditator does is stop and look at the object, seeing it penetratively. To see the object penetratively means to see the impermanence (aniccatā) of the object. That which was taken as an object is something that arises and passes away with extreme rapidity. Now let us suppose we are looking at a candle flame. That large candle flame appears very beautiful, yellow, or with a slight touch of red, in a lovely manner. How is this seen when that meditative attention is developed? Like a heap of candle flames arising and passing away with extreme rapidity. It is not a single flame. Similarly, let us suppose there is a stream of water flowing. Or rather, water pouring from something. Now, in a water spout or a waterfall, the stream of water appears from afar like a silver wall. When looking closely, ultimately what is there is a stream of water falling and breaking up with extreme rapidity, not remaining in the same state for even a single moment. And it is seen dispersing. It is understood as one only because of taking it with the perception of compactness. But to wisdom, to comprehension, it is understood in the end that there is nothing here to be taken as one. 'There is nothing.' This object is ultimately seen penetratively. This is a very wondrous thing. It starts with the

object. It starts by noting the object. But it ends with seeing the emptiness of the object—seeing the object penetratively.

It is through that penetrative seeing that ultimately it is directly realized by oneself: 'there is nothing here to grasp as "I" and "mine".' If there is an 'I', then there is something that belongs to me; if there is no 'I', there is also nothing that belongs to me. Likewise, one understands that this perception of 'I' is a certain ignorance (*avijjā*), a delusion (*moha*) deposited in the mind over a long period through ignorance, which society instigates and tries to retain. Now, a person cannot make society understand this realization by shouting. This cannot be made to happen by telling anyone. Why was Ven. Poṭhila unable to understand this despite learning so many books? The Buddha declared this Dhamma as well-proclaimed (*svākkhāto*); this Dhamma is visible here and now (*sandiṭṭhiko*), timeless (*akāliko*), inviting to come and see (*ehi-passiko*), leading onwards (*opanayiko*), and to be personally realized by the wise (*paccattam veditabbo viññūhi*), and so on, in various terms. Why? This is something to be directly realized by the wise themselves. Another cannot make one realize this. The path to be applied for that is what was called 'Yoga'—meditative attention, the correct form of meditative attention.

Taking some meditation subject—let us say, mindfulness of breathing (*ānāpāna*)—through this process of inhalation and exhalation, which stays with us from birth to death, some people can bring forth this aforementioned knowledge. That is a very well-known fact. Now, though we say we take a breath, what is here is a heap of breath-waves. To exhale a breath is also a heap of waves—a heap of vibrations there too. But this wavy nature is usually not understood. Why is it not understood? 'I am breathing.' 'This is my breath.' Let us suppose we took a breath filled with the fragrance of nice flowers, with great attachment. Or we took a breath with something like the fragrance of incense. 'I took a breath, but we cannot hold onto it. Such is the cosmic order (*dhammatā*). No matter how desirously we take a breath, we cannot retain it. Later, we suffocate. Therefore, that breath must be expelled. Within that exhalation lies a similar heap of vibrations. So, in the end, when we look, we have to say that what arises is a heap of vibrations, and what passes away is a heap of vibrations. Ultimately, after that too has passed away, even those vibrations are understood by a person in an extremely subtle manner. This cannot be understood by a person through external machines, no matter how subtle those machines may be. It is only through the wisdom developed within oneself that this is understood by a person. It is through this understanding that a person is able to let go of this five aggregates. Trying to escape from this physical body by destroying oneself does not solve that problem. It only worsens the problem. Next, according to karma, one is born again somewhere. Now, many people, speaking of life-

sacrifice or life-surrender, sacrifice their lives for something they hold dear, or someone they hold dear—treating it as a great thing. One cannot escape from this saṃsāra in that way. For the habituation of consciousness (viññāṇa) possesses such a great pull. But instead, what is advised to be done is to directly realize those supramundane states through wisdom.

There are four levels of escaping from this saṃsāra, called Stream-entry (Sotāpanna), Once-returning (Sakadāgāmi), Non-returning (Anāgāmi), and Arahantship. Within our minds, there are forces that pull us to the four lower realms (apāya), evil forces. In the supramundane wisdom of the Stream-enterer, there is a power that destroys those unwholesome forces. A Stream-enterer is not born more than seven times in saṃsāra. Likewise, he does not go to the four lower realms. That is the greatest guarantee received through Stream-entry itself. That is why the Buddha preached that the fruit of Stream-entry is supreme compared to sovereign lordship over the entire world, compared to being a universal monarch, compared to going to heaven. For if one is a universal monarch, he is a righteous king. But in the ordinary world, kingship is a state where committing sin is unavoidable. As a result of those sins committed, next, one is born in the terrible lower realms, in states of ghosts (peta) and demons (yakkha). But the Stream-enterer is freed from the four lower realms. That is the first supramundane state. Next, Once-returning means coming back to this world only once more. Perhaps being born in a heavenly world, and then being born in the human world only once more. All of these are named according to how they shorten saṃsāra. Non-returning is the third state. He does not return to this world. Ending the suffering of saṃsāra in the Brahma world itself, he attains final extinguishment through sublime Arahantship. This is the last life of the Arahant. After this life, there is no birth (jāti) again. Although the ordinary world conducts grand celebrations saying 'someone is born,' 'it is a birthday'—how much suffering is birth? The child does not remember it, and sometimes the mother does not remember it either. Not only that, if we look with our eyes wide open, according to the state of the world, is it not because of birth that all these calamities arise? This physical body of ours is also due to this birth. Through the craving (taṇhā) we formed in the past, through mental grasping, we received a certain body according to karma. Sometimes one might be born maimed, mute, or deaf; how much suffering does one have to undergo because of that? Well, let us suppose we are born without any of those, in a healthy state of mind and body. Even then, to nourish this body, to keep it in health, from the day of birth, if someone—like our parents—nourishes us, we can live. When we reach a stage where we can no longer hang onto them, next, we must earn and provide with the sweat of our brow, struggling, and undergoing various sufferings. Such is the situation for protecting this life—for guarding this physical body. Thus, the

suffering that arises because of birth. Next, what comes along with birth is decay (jarā). From the day of birth, one decays. Usually, we say we have aged, we have reached old age, by setting some limit—saying it is after 40, or 35. But in truth, this decaying starts from birth itself. The hair that was born, or whatever, goes on decaying. When this decaying accelerates, affliction and disease (vyādhi) come. Gradually, illness accumulates and worsens this problem. Ultimately, this ends in death (maraṇa).

It was because of these four—birth, decay, disease, and death—that the Buddha renounced such royal luxuries and departed. Other sufferings in the world are secondary. They can increase or decrease. But these are common to all. Therefore, if someone reflects on this saṃsāric condition with wisdom, instead of running after the vast accumulation of knowledge which the world has grasped as convention, what is to be done, as Ven. Poṭhila did in the end, as he learned that 'lesson' in the end, is to engage in this path of practice declared by the Buddha—Yoga. One must depart from Ayoga and engage in Yoga. Yoga means meditative attention (bhāvanā manasikāra). In this manner, taking some meditation subject, approaching those who can give instructions on them, and obtaining and following their instructions—humbly, like Ven. Poṭhila—one must walk on that path of Dhamma. This has been a futile running in saṃsāra for a long time. Like the deer running after the mirage, in this life we form certain targets in our childhood. The small child, looking at the lives of adults, forms desires after their lands, properties, and vehicles they use. Those very things are given to the young child as toys, placed in front of him on the day of his first solid feeding. Those are the target objects of his parents' desires. Those objects are what that small child goes and grasps on the day of first solid feeding. Next, that child dedicates his entire life to the thing he grasped. Those are the toys of small children. There is no need to speak anew about the toys of grown-up children. They spend their entire lives after them. Sometimes they sacrifice their lives. But in the end, those are empty things. One can never escape from saṃsāra through such things.

Instead, what is to be done is to stop that running and try to stop the mind, by means of a meditation subject. What the Buddha said even to the thief Aṅgulimāla, that bandit, was: 'I have stopped, you too stop.' It is like that. This stopping is what is needed for the world—not running. Everyone invites us to run. Stopping this running is what is called meditative stillness. To aid this, by means of a meditation subject, noting the objects coming to the sense doors very subtly as they arise—with mindfulness and clear comprehension (sati-sampajañña)—a person becomes able to realize the three characteristics of impermanent (anicca), suffering (dukkha), and non-self (anattā) within himself. If everything changes, if everything is of the nature of arising and passing away, if

we are oppressed by them, if they break up with extreme rapidity, this is a very dangerous thing—this is suffering (dukkha). If we are repairing and using a vehicle whose parts are falling apart, how much trouble is that? How much suffering? In the same way is this body of ours. Even if we take food and drink, in a few hours we must nourish it again. We take this breath with great attachment, thinking it is the sweet fragrance of flowers, but we are forced to expel it. It is the same with other things. Due to this breaking up nature—this changing nature, this transiency—the Buddha declared this as suffering (dukkha). Identifying the three characteristics must be the target of everyone's life: the characteristic of impermanence (anicca), next the characteristic of suffering (dukkha), and next the characteristic of non-self (anattā). If this is suffering, if it is a thing of suffering, if there is in truth no pleasure here, how can we proudly say 'I' and 'mine'? It is because it cannot be maintained according to our wishes that it breaks up. If we can say it is 'mine', it must remain as we want. But this is not such a thing. In a way we did not think of, at a moment we did not think of, the things we wish for, the things we are holding onto, the things we possess, change, break up, are destroyed, and depart. Such is the nature that exists in this saṃsāra.

The person who has directly realized this nature with wisdom is the one who obtains that sublime bliss of Nibbāna, which is called 'the settling of all formations' (sabba-saṅkhāra-samatha). The extinguishment, Nibbāna is extinction. In this entire world, in this entire saṃsāra, there is what is called a burning. In a very wondrous way, there is a burning inside and outside in the world. The Buddha has declared, 'O monks, everything is burning.' The eye, ear, nose, and so on—all of these are burning. It is within such a multitude of burnings that the worldlings exist. Through the Dhamma He declared, the Buddha, having freed Himself from these burnings, has shown the path to that cooling called 'Nibbāna'. That path of practice is what is called the Buddha's teaching. Its core is the engagement in that practice. Therefore, you meritorious people, having undertaken a valuable virtue today on this valuable Poya day—the virtue of the Eight Precepts—(there are also meritorious people here who have undertaken virtue more valuable than their lives)—having disciplined body and speech in whatever manner, you have now listened to several Dhamma points related to the Buddha's teaching. Through this—whether through the similes we presented or other narratives—even if you absorb only the practical portion necessary for your daily lives, that is enough, even if not everything. Next, what is important is to make this in daily life—not as something to be tested—but to integrate it into your lifestyle, to integrate it into your daily routine, to dedicate a small amount of time during the day to this meditative attention, even a few minutes, and then, if possible when there is leisure, or even by making leisure, to

turn towards these. I hope that you will direct your lives towards that sublime task, action, and target of liberation from saṃsāra—the realization of Nibbāna—a very important task that was missed due to falling into negligence in this long saṃsāra.

Therefore, at this time, during this sermon, we believe that several valuable Dhamma qualities that help towards Nibbāna have been deposited in your minds. You listened to this with faith (saddhā). Faith is a very valuable quality. So much so that the Buddha declares faith as a spiritual faculty (indriya) that helps realize Nibbāna, and also as a power (bala). Mindfulness (sati), concentration (samādhi), and wisdom (paññā)—we believe that you meritorious people have gained the strength to develop these to some extent by listening and reflecting on this sermon. Therefore, considering the strength you received as the benefit of hearing the Dhamma today, if a great store of wholesome feelings/sensations (vedanā) arose by directing a pure mind, body, and speech to these, let us now share those merits with those who expect and desire merits.

If we have accumulated a sublime store of merit through preaching and listening to the Dhamma at this time, may the devas and brahmas who protect the Dispensation, and especially all those deities who guard this place, rejoice in this store of merit! According to their own aspirations, may they realize the supreme, deathless, great Nibbāna through whichever path of awakening they choose! May they provide protection to the Dispensation and to us! Such is the aspiration we must make. Likewise, including our own relatives, whichever host of beings from Avīci to Akaniṭṭha who desire merit and desire Nibbāna—may all of them rejoice in this sublime merit and, as quickly as possible, realize the supreme, deathless, great Nibbāna through their aspired path of awakening! Reciting these verses, share the merits.

“*Ettāvatā ca amhehi.....*”